Do Hobbies Decrease as Academic Pressure Increases?

Abstract: This survey examines whether academic pressure reduces students' engagement in hobbies. Using responses from 107 students aged 13–25+, it analyses workload, stress ratings, causes of stress (financial pressure, coursework, exams), study hours, and perceived effects of hobbies on well-being and performance. Results show high stress and polarised study schedules, with many students valuing hobbies but lacking time-management strategies to integrate them. The study highlights the need for practical tools to balance academics and personal interests for improved mental health and productivity.

Keywords: Academic Pressure, Hobbies, Workload, Stress Management, Time Management, Student Well-being, Productivity, Academic Performance, Mental Health, Balance

Introduction, Research Gap & Objectives

Introduction: Academic life places substantial demands on students through exams, heavy coursework, and career expectations. Hobbies act as outlets that support relaxation, creativity, and emotional health, and can indirectly benefit academic outcomes by reducing stress and improving concentration. This study explores whether increased academic pressure corresponds to decreased engagement in hobbies and seeks patterns across age and study-level groups.

Research gap: Existing literature recognises the benefits of hobbies but few campus surveys quantify how academic pressure shifts hobby engagement across diverse student levels (middle school to graduate). This study fills that gap by surveying students across age groups and study levels to identify drivers of reduced hobby participation.

Objectives: 1. Examine how academic workload and stress levels affect students' engagement in hobbies. 2. Identify main sources of academic pressure (exams, assignments, finances, parental expectations). 3. Understand the role of hobbies in mental health, productivity, and academic performance. 4. Recommend practical time-management and stress-reduction tools to help students balance responsibilities.

Methodology

Methodology: Research approach: Quantitative survey-based study. Sample size: 107 respondents aged 13–25+ from middle school, high school, undergraduate and graduate levels. Survey tool: Google Forms with 10 structured questions covering workload, stress level, study hours, hobby engagement, time management, and perceived effects on performance. Analysis: Data tabulation, categorization and descriptive statistics to identify trends and relationships.

Data Analysis (Questions with unique/most-frequent respon

Total responses: 107. Below are questions from the survey along with the most frequent/unique responses and summary statistics derived from the dataset.

Q1. What is your academic workload? Most common response: Heavy (26.2%). Moderate: 22.4%. Very Heavy: 18.7%. Light: 17.8%. Very Light: 15%.

Q2. How would you rate your academic stress (1-10)? Most frequent rating: 8 (15% of respondents). Ratings 6 (14%), 3 and 10 (12.1% each).

Q3. What are the main causes of academic stress? Top causes selected: Financial pressures (65.4%), Heavy coursework/assignments (60.7%), Exams/tests (59.8%), Future career concerns (58.9%), Parental expectations (57%), Time management challenges (50.5%).

Q4. How many hours per day do you spend on academics? Polarised results: <2 hours (27 respondents), >10 hours (25), 8-10 hours (23), 2-4 hours (21), 5-7 hours (11).

Q5. Do you think hobbies help with mental health / productivity? Yes (most common, 21 respondents), Maybe (19), No (8), Never thought about it (8).

Q6. Have you tried time-management tools to balance hobbies and studies? No – never tried (22 respondents). Tried but not consistent (14). Yes – it works well (11). Don't believe it helps (16).

Q7. How do hobbies affect your academic performance? 22.4% believe hobbies have no effect, 19.6% not sure, 15.9% slightly improve, 15.9% significantly improve, 13.1% slightly worsen, 13.1% significantly worsen.

Q8. Do you believe superstitions/luck impact outcomes (e.g., lucky socks, black cats)? Responses varied; many see some role of luck in outcomes, while others don't—survey captures perceptions rather than causal belief.

Q9. If a friend is late, what do you assume? Most common: They forgot (69.4%).

Q10. When reading opinions online, which do you prefer? Most common: Information that matches your beliefs (79%).

Findings, Conclusion & References

Findings: 1. High workload and stress: Majority report heavy workloads and elevated stress ratings, with finances, coursework, and exams as top stressors. 2. Time-management gap: Many students value hobbies but lack consistent use of time-management tools to integrate them. 3. Polarised academic schedules: Large groups spend either very little (<2 hours) or very high (>10 hours) time on academics, indicating inconsistent study patterns. 4. Mixed perceived impact of hobbies: Responses are split on whether hobbies improve academic performance, suggesting differing personal experiences and priorities. Overall, students recognise the benefits of hobbies but face barriers (time, stress, finances) to maintaining them.

Conclusion: The survey indicates academic pressure often crowds out time for hobbies despite students acknowledging their benefits. To support student well-being, institutions should promote practical time-management training, accessible stress-reduction resources, and create space in curricula for recreational activities. Addressing financial and workload stressors will also help students better integrate hobbies into daily life.

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